

Regrading Decision Guide

A practical guide to help organisations decide when a role should be regraded — and when another solution is more appropriate.

01 Introduction

One of the most common pressures in job evaluation is the request to regrade a role. Sometimes that request is justified. Sometimes it is not. The challenge is knowing the difference.

A disciplined approach to regrading protects the integrity of the whole grading framework. Without that discipline, organisations can start using regrading to solve issues that are not really about role size at all — such as pay concerns, retention pressure, performance, or temporary operational demands. That is when confidence in the grading system begins to weaken. This guide is designed to help organisations think clearly about when regrading is appropriate, when it is not, and what good governance should look like in the decision.

02 What should trigger regrading?

A regrading request is generally more likely to be justified where the role itself has changed in a material and ongoing way. This may include situations such as:

- significant change in the role's scope or complexity
- meaningful expansion of accountabilities
- material increase in technical depth
- significant increase in management or leadership accountability
- formal structural change affecting the role
- expansion of the role's overall portfolio
- creation of new business lines, functions, or operating responsibilities
- broader organisational or strategic shift that has materially changed the role's design

The key test is not whether the role feels busier or more pressured — it is whether the actual size of the role has changed in a lasting and demonstrable way.

03 What should not trigger regrading?

A number of issues may feel important or urgent, but they do not automatically justify regrading. These typically include:

- temporary increases in workload
- the strong performance of an individual
- short-term or abnormal circumstances
- acting responsibilities during an absence
- market scarcity of skills
- geographic or external market pressures
- possible future changes that have not yet happened
- attempts to retain an employee
- length of service or tenure
- new ways of working that do not fundamentally change the nature of the role

These may all require a management, reward, or organisational response. But they are not necessarily job evaluation issues — and that distinction matters. A grading framework loses credibility when regrading becomes a response to people pressure instead of role change.

04 How to distinguish role change from people issues

A useful discipline is to ask: is the issue about the job, or about the person?

A ROLE ISSUE IS ABOUT

- ✓ what the job is now required to do
- ✓ what level of accountability it now carries
- ✓ what level of complexity it now involves
- ✓ how its place in the structure has changed

A PEOPLE ISSUE IS ABOUT

- ✗ performance
- ✗ retention
- ✗ capability
- ✗ pay dissatisfaction
- ✗ temporary overload
- ✗ employee expectations

These are not the same thing. For example:

- a high-performing employee does not automatically mean the role is larger
- a scarce-skill issue may be a pay issue, not a grading issue
- a temporary increase in work does not necessarily mean the role has changed
- frustration with pay may indicate a reward problem rather than a role-size problem

A good regrading process helps the organisation separate these questions rather than treating them as one.

05 What evidence should support a regrading request?

A regrading request should not rely on opinion alone. Before a role is reconsidered, there should be enough evidence to show that the role has changed materially. Useful evidence may include:

- an updated and signed-off job profile or job description
- a clear explanation of what has changed
- evidence that the changes are ongoing, not temporary
- confirmation of reporting-line or structural changes
- clarity on how the role's outputs, accountabilities, or complexity have shifted
- organisational context to show why the change matters

A regrading request should be grounded in credible information, not only perception.

06 Governance questions to ask before regrading

Before moving forward, ask:

- Is the request based on a real role change?
- Is the role information current and credible?
- Is the change significant enough to justify review?
- Has the request been raised through the correct process?
- Have the relevant line manager and HR stakeholders reviewed it?
- Is there sufficient documentation to support evaluation?
- Is the request being driven by role evidence rather than employee pressure?

If the answer to several of these is no, more clarification may be needed before regrading is considered.

07 What good governance looks like in regrading decisions

Strong governance helps ensure that regrading remains disciplined rather than reactive. Good governance usually includes:

- a clear request process
- defined approval rights
- evidence requirements
- review by the appropriate committee or evaluator
- validation where a grade change is material
- documentation of the rationale and outcome
- a clear route for disagreement or appeal where necessary

This does not mean the process needs to become bureaucratic. It means the process should be fair, consistent, explainable, and sustainable over time. That is what protects the credibility of the grading framework.

08 A simple decision view

REGRADING MAY BE APPROPRIATE WHEN

- ✓ the role has materially changed in scope or complexity
- ✓ accountabilities have expanded on an ongoing basis
- ✓ technical or leadership requirements have significantly increased
- ✓ structural or portfolio changes have altered the role meaningfully
- ✓ new functions or major changes in business context have reshaped the job

REGRADING IS USUALLY NOT APPROPRIATE WHEN

- ✗ workload has increased temporarily
- ✗ an individual is performing strongly
- ✗ market pay pressure exists
- ✗ retention risk has emerged
- ✗ future changes are being anticipated but have not happened
- ✗ acting duties or temporary cover arrangements are in place
- ✗ tenure or service length is being used as justification

FINAL READINESS QUESTIONS

Before submitting or approving a regrading request, ask:

- Has the role itself changed materially?
- Is the evidence strong enough to support review?
- Are we responding to a role issue rather than a people issue?
- Is the request going through the correct governance route?
- Will the organisation be able to explain and defend the decision clearly?

If the answer is yes, regrading may be justified. If not, another response may be more appropriate.

FINAL NOTE

A strong grading framework does not only depend on evaluating roles well. It also depends on knowing when *not* to regrade. That is one of the most important disciplines in job evaluation. Done well, it protects fairness, consistency, and confidence in the system over time.

Assess regrading requests with confidence

Book a working session and use Engage to strengthen the governance around your grading decisions.

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Engage Job Evaluation is a methodology of Africa People Advisory Group (APAG). · engage.africapeopleadvisory.com